



I'm not focusing on the Worlds — I'm looking forward to the Commonwealth Games and Asian Games next year," said Kujur.

The Bronze event lost some sheen due to the absence of several well-known Indian athletes — including Olympic medallist Neeraj, Asian Games silver medallist Kishore Jena, national record-holding distance runner Gulveer Singh, steeplechasers Avinash Sable and Parul Chaudhary, triple jumper Praveen Chithravel, sprinters Gurindervir Singh and Manikanta Hoblidhar, and long jumper Ancy Sojan — owing to various reasons. Many withdrawals were injury or

fitness related.

Even so, Indian dominance in an international field of 156 athletes from over 15 countries was a foregone conclusion. This was perhaps best illustrated in the women's section, where the Indians completed a clean sweep.

Among other notable performances, triple jumper Abdulla Aboobacker, with a season best of 17.19m, jumped 16.53m in his third attempt to beat compatriot Karthik Unnikrishnan by 11cm.

Vishal T.K. clocked 45.72 to take the men's 400m title, with second-placed Amoj Jacob — who had run 50.26 in the heats —

Speed merchant: Kujur, the national record holder with 20.32 set at the Asian Championships in May, stormed to the 200m title in 20.77.

recording his season best of 45.86.

By hosting the event, the Odisha Government continued its policy of promoting sport. Apart from allocating close to ₹10 crore, including prize money (\$800, \$400, \$300 and \$200 for first to fourth place respectively) and organisational costs, the government brought in schoolchildren to fill the stands and arranged folk dance performances to give the event a festive feel.

The Athletics Federation of India (AFI), which aims to raise the Bronze event's status in future and hopes one day to host the World Championships, will need to fine-tune operational areas to ensure smoother conduct of the competition.

« The Ramaraj sisters faced heartbreak: Vithya was disqualified for a false start in 400m, and Nithya fell while leading in the 100m hurdles »